

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Human Resources English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For HR business partners, recruiters, talent managers, people managers, employee-relations staff, learning teams, compensation analysts, and HR-adjacent leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Hiring criteria

02 Onboarding handoff

03 Performance conversation preparation

04 Employee relations intake

05 Benefits explanation

06 Compensation review

07 Policy rollout

08 Workplace conflict

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Hiring criteria

HR and a hiring manager refine a vacancy.

Roles: Recruiter / Hiring manager

Recruiter: The brief asks for ten years of experience. Which responsibilities actually require that?

Hiring manager: Leading complex client projects and coaching the team. The number was a shortcut.

Recruiter: Let's describe the relevant skills and evidence candidates can demonstrate.

Hiring manager: Agreed. We can assess a comparable project example rather than use years alone.

Recruiter: I'll revise the selection criteria and align the interview questions.

Hiring manager: I'll review them with the panel before we advertise, so everyone evaluates the same requirements.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The brief asks for ten years of experience. Which responsibilities actually require that?"
What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Onboarding handoff

HR checks readiness for a new starter.

Roles: HR coordinator / Line manager

HR coordinator: The new starter joins Monday. Have their access requests and induction schedule been confirmed?

Line manager: Equipment is ready, but the system owner hasn't approved one role.

HR coordinator: Keep that access pending. We can arrange an appropriate first-day schedule without bypassing approval.

Line manager: I'll assign a buddy and confirm the tasks they can begin.

HR coordinator: I'll send the induction details and required forms through the approved channel.

Line manager: I'll own the team introduction and check the outstanding access request before the end of the day.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The new starter joins Monday. Have their access requests and induction schedule been confirmed?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Performance conversation preparation

HR helps a manager prepare concrete feedback.

Roles: HR partner / Team manager

HR partner: You wrote that the employee lacks commitment. What observable work issue are you addressing?

Team manager: Three agreed reports were late, and I don't yet know why.

HR partner: Start with those examples and their effect, then ask about barriers and support.

Team manager: I'll avoid guessing at motivation and agree on a clear reporting expectation.

HR partner: Follow the applicable performance process and document the discussion accurately.

Team manager: I'll give them space to respond and arrange a review of the agreed next steps.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "You wrote that the employee lacks commitment. What observable work issue are you addressing?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Employee relations intake

HR receives a concern from a supervisor.

Roles: HR adviser / Department supervisor

HR adviser: Please describe what was reported and what you observed yourself.

Department supervisor: An employee described repeated dismissive comments. I witnessed one interruption, but not the other incidents.

HR adviser: Keep that distinction clear. Don't characterize an allegation as an established finding.

Department supervisor: Should I speak to the whole team today?

HR adviser: Let's follow the appropriate intake and investigation process, including confidentiality limits and protection against retaliation.

Department supervisor: I'll provide the factual record through the designated channel and avoid conducting an informal group inquiry.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Should I speak to the whole team today?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Benefits explanation

HR clarifies an ambiguous benefits question.

Roles: Benefits specialist / HR coordinator

Benefits specialist: An employee asks whether this treatment is covered. I don't want to interpret the plan beyond the documents.

HR coordinator: Explain the available plan information and route the specific coverage question to the authorized administrator.

Benefits specialist: Should I tell them reimbursement is likely?

HR coordinator: Avoid predicting a claim decision. Give them the required contact and documentation process.

Benefits specialist: I'll distinguish a general eligibility explanation from approval of a particular claim.

HR coordinator: Good. Record the referral without retaining unnecessary sensitive medical details.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Should I tell them reimbursement is likely?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Compensation review

HR and a manager discuss a pay adjustment.

Roles: Compensation analyst / Department manager

Compensation analyst: What is the basis for the proposed increase: role change, market position, or performance?

Department manager: The role now includes regional responsibility. I want the review to reflect that scope.

Compensation analyst: Then we need the updated duties and the relevant job-evaluation evidence.

Department manager: I'll provide those rather than compare only with one colleague's salary.

Compensation analyst: I'll assess the proposal against the applicable range and review process.

Department manager: I'll avoid promising an amount before the authorized decision is made.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "What is the basis for the proposed increase: role change, market position, or performance?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Policy rollout

HR prepares to explain a revised working arrangement.

Roles: HR policy lead / People manager

HR policy lead: The draft says flexibility is available, but it doesn't explain the approval process.

People manager: Staff will need to know eligibility, request steps, and how role requirements are considered.

HR policy lead: I'll add those details and distinguish a request from an approved arrangement.

People manager: Include a way to ask about individual circumstances without discussing private information in a team meeting.

HR policy lead: We'll brief managers using consistent examples and current policy language.

People manager: I'll gather questions and escalate unclear cases rather than invent a local rule.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The draft says flexibility is available, but it doesn't explain the approval process." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Workplace conflict

An HR partner helps two managers address a handoff dispute.

Roles: HR partner / Operations manager / Service manager

HR partner: Let's describe the handoff problem without assigning motives. What is happening?

Operations manager: Requests reach us without the information needed to schedule work.

Service manager: Our staff don't know which fields are essential, so they send what they have.

HR partner: Can you agree on a minimum handoff and a route for urgent incomplete requests?

Operations manager: I'll identify the required information and explain why each item matters.

Service manager: I'll test that checklist with our team and bring any impractical steps back for review.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Let's describe the handoff problem without assigning motives. What is happening?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

SHARED CASE

A hiring manager asks for a candidate with "good cultural fit." The role requirements do not explain which behaviors matter.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Which job-related behaviors do you mean? Let's use clear requirements and consistent interview questions so candidates are assessed against the work the role actually involves.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Onboarding and Role Clarity

SHARED CASE

A new starter has accounts and equipment but no first-month priorities. Their manager assumes the onboarding checklist covers expectations.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could we agree on three first-month priorities and a check-in date? The checklist covers setup; the new starter also needs to know what successful work looks like.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Performance Feedback and Documentation

SHARED CASE

An employee's last two reports omitted the agreed summary section. The manager wants to discuss the issue without making a judgment about motivation.

Role A | Responding professional

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Useful expressions

In [specific situation], I noticed

The effect was What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The last two reports did not include the summary section we agreed on. That made review slower. What would help you include it consistently, and can we check the next report together?

Second round

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Employee Relations and Investigations

SHARED CASE

An employee raises a concern about a colleague. The receiving manager has only one account and is preparing an intake note.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

I'll record the concern in the employee's own terms and distinguish reported information from established findings. The appropriate process should determine the next steps; we should not prejudge the outcome.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Compensation, Benefits, and Equity

SHARED CASE

An employee sees a published pay range and assumes everyone in the role receives the midpoint. The HR team has the relevant compensation policy.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The range describes the span for the role, not a promise of the midpoint. Let's review the applicable policy and the factors the organization uses to explain an individual's position within the range.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Policy Communication and Compliance

SHARED CASE

A manager asks whether a requested work adjustment is automatically approved. HR has not yet reviewed the request under the applicable process.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you describe the requested adjustment and the work requirement involved? We'll review it through the appropriate process. I cannot confirm an outcome before that review.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Conflict Mediation and Manager Coaching

SHARED CASE

Two colleagues disagree about who owns a recurring task. Both say the other failed to help, but the responsibilities were never documented.

Role A | Responding professional

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Useful expressions

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Let's identify the task, the handoff point, and what each person understood. Then we can agree on responsibilities and a check-in instead of continuing with assumptions about intent.

Second round

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Restructuring and Sensitive Communication

SHARED CASE

A restructuring message uses the phrase "small changes" even though some positions may be affected. The final details are not yet confirmed.

Role A | Responding professional

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Useful expressions

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Cover this until after your first attempt

The wording may understate the possible impact. Let's say clearly what is confirmed, what remains undecided, and where employees can ask questions, using the approved communication process.

Second round

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.